KARNATAKA

A New Quota Calculus

By Ajay Sukumaran

The clamour among Other Backward Class (OBC) groups in Karnataka for a larger slice of reservations for education and employment ran into a novel twist in the last week of December. Wary of upsetting two of the dominant castes in the state—Lingayats and Vokkaligas—especially with a state election to face in about four months, the Basavaraj Bommai government moved quickly to acquiesce to their demands for a higher share of reservation quota. However, it professed to do this by carrying out a reshuffle of the existing OBC reservation categories—a surprise move that has thrown up more questions than answers.

The plethora of reservation demands from various communities has been a Pandora's Box that Karnataka's ruling BJP has been cautious about. But it opened one up in October by issuing an ordinance to increase the reservation for scheduled castes and tribes from the existing 18 per cent to 24 per cent. This was based on a report by a committee set up by the previous government in 2019 to examine a long-pending demand to raise SC/ST reservations given that they now covered over 150 castes and that their component populations had increased anyway. However, this additional 6 per cent took Karnataka's total reservation (including the 32 per cent set aside for OBCs) beyond the Supreme Court's 50 per cent limit, which it was already at.



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POLL-ITICKING! Chief minister Basavaraj Bommai

Hence, while the BJP was eyeing the goodwill from Dalit sections with this move, the OBC communities only intensified their demands for a similar quota hike. On December 22, amid the Karnataka legislature's winter session, the Panchamashali subset of the Lingayat community took out a massive rally led by their seer Basava Jaya Mruthyunjaya Swamiji and legislators from both the ruling BJP and opposition Congress, giving the government an ultimatum on this count. The Lingayats are the state's largest caste group and a mainstay of the BJP's support base. However, the Vokkaliga community, the state's second-biggest caste group, also put forth the threat of an agitation.

Karnataka's 32 per cent reservation for OBCs is spread across five categories—graded from the most backward to relatively backward—and each with varying quotas. While the Lingayats as a group currently come under Category III(b), a slab eligible for a 5 per cent reservation, the Panchamashalis have been agitating to be moved up to Category II(a), which has a 15 per cent reservation.